



Epicentre of emotions: Eight major matches — Indian top division and international — have been played at Shillong's Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium since its renovation in 2024, with the venue averaging at least 86 per cent capacity. ISL

MATCH MADE IN HEAVEN

From rock anthems to **roaring crowds**, Shillong dreams to be India's football capital.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

Shillong has two things quintessential to it: football and music. For most of the year, the streets here are adorned with either banners of music festivals or players of the local club, Shillong Lajong, competing in the I-League.

The capital city has been touted as the rock capital of India, having hosted concerts by artistes like the Scorpions and Steven Wilson to nurtured home-grown bands like Soulmate, Afflatus, and Aberrant. Even Chief Minister Conrad Sangma is an electric guitar player and often performs on stage.

On the footballing front, Shillong is a prominent landmark among the Seven Sisters — seven states of north-east India — being the home venue of Lajong.

Previously known as Lajong FC, the club has been a touchstone for some of the best domestic talents in India — some from Meghalaya and many more from the neighbouring states.

"Football may not be the most loved sport in the country, but it is the most loved sport in Meghalaya. Our boys and girls are very passionate about football," Sangma told *Sportstar* in a select media interaction.

Redeem Tlang and Aibanbha Dohling — former Lajong players from the state — have won the Durand Cup with NorthEast United and FC Goa, respectively.

Meanwhile, Vishal Kaith (a two-time ISL Shield winner and an ISL Cup winner), Chinglensana Singh (ISL and Super Cup winner), Naorem Mahesh Singh (one-time Super Cup winner), and Bipin Singh (a two-time